Open Publishing Exchange
2026 Landscape and Executive Summary

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Executive Summary

The Open Publishing Exchange (OPE), formerly the Center for Scholarly Publishing, is K-State Libraries' campus hub for sustainable open knowledge infrastructure. OPE brings together open educational resources, repository services, New Prairie Press, and data services so that K-State faculty, students, and partners have practical pathways to publish, preserve, share, and reuse scholarly and educational work.

The 2026-27 strategic question is no longer whether this work belongs in the Libraries. It does. The strategic question is how OPE can make these services sustainable: financially, operationally, technically, and intellectually. The department's next phase should focus on building evidence-driven services that scale through external funding, student-supported affordability initiatives, formal publishing agreements, and a parallel research program in scholarly communication and open infrastructure.

OPE should organize its 2026 work around four service lines: OER, Repository, Scholarly Publishing through New Prairie Press, and Data Services. Across these areas, sustainability should be the unifying frame: reduce hidden labor, clarify service commitments, document impact, recover costs where appropriate, and build durable infrastructure aligned with K-State's land-grant and R1 responsibilities.

Mission and 2026-27 Positioning

OPE advances open, equitable, and sustainable scholarly communication at K-State by supporting the full lifecycle of public knowledge: creation, publication, preservation, access, reuse, and evidence of impact.

In 2026, OPE should be framed less as a collection of related services and more as a coordinated exchange: a place where teaching materials, publications, datasets, repositories, grants, and research infrastructure meet. This framing preserves the department's "open" philosophy while making the work legible to the university as mission-aligned scholarly infrastructure rather than a generic menu of support services.

The 2026-27 Landscape: From Expansion to Sustainability

The scholarly communication landscape continues to be shaped by rising publishing costs, federal public-access and data-sharing expectations, textbook affordability pressures, and increasing faculty demand for support with publishing, preservation, compliance, and impact reporting. K-State has already built strong foundations through K-REx, New Prairie Press, OATI, Pressbooks/LibreTexts, copyright support, and emerging data services. The next step is to make those foundations sustainable and measurable.

For OPE, sustainability has four meanings:

1. **Financial sustainability:** services should have clear funding paths through student fees, endowments, grants, MOUs, cost recovery, or university investment.
2. **Operational sustainability:** services should have defined workflows, staffing, scope, and expectations so growth does not depend on heroic labor.
3. **Technical sustainability:** platform decisions should support preservation, interoperability, accessibility, metadata quality, and realistic maintenance.

4. **Intellectual sustainability:** OPE should build a research program that studies scholarly communication, open infrastructure, data publishing, OER, and evidence of impact.

Core Service Lines

Service Line	Primary Work	2026 Sustainability Focus
OER	Open/Alternative Textbook Initiative, BOER support, Pressbooks/LibreTexts, faculty adoption and creation support, affordability reporting.	Stabilize funding through Student Government Association support, strengthen governance through BOER, and pursue an endowed OER librarian position.
Repository	K-REx, ETDR and RSCAD deposit, metadata, preservation, repository guidance, public access support, and future data repository coordination.	Clarify the relationship between institutional repository services and research data repository needs; invest in metadata, preservation, PIDs, and reporting.
Scholarly Publishing (NPP)	Journals, monographs, proceedings, open books, editorial workflows, accessibility, platform transition, and publishing consultation.	Formalize external use through MOUs, define cost-recovery models, and add editorial capacity for NPP and OER outputs.
Data Services	DMPs, FAIR guidance, repository selection, data publication, grant planning, data management language, and research lifecycle support.	Build a grant-support service line with a project coordinator distributed across active grants, targeting no fewer than three concurrent grants as a sustainable staffing model.

2026 Sustainability Agenda

1. Build grant support through Data Services

OPE should become a routine grant partner for projects that need data management, metadata, repository planning, open publishing, public access compliance, DOI/PID strategy, or research-output reporting. The model should be simple: early consultation and budget language are broadly available, while larger projects build OPE support into grants through subawards, service agreements, or approved internal budget structures.

This work should also support OPE's own research program. Grant-funded service work can generate practical questions, datasets, workflows, and case studies that support research on data publishing, scholarly infrastructure, open access, OER, and evidence of impact.

2. Formalize external use of New Prairie Press

NPP already functions as a public-facing publishing infrastructure. In 2026, OPE should formalize how external journals, proceedings, associations, and partner projects use NPP. A standard MOU should clarify eligibility, responsibilities, editorial independence, platform support, accessibility expectations, branding, fees, fundraising rules, and exit terms.

The goal is not to commercialize NPP. The goal is to protect staff time, make commitments explicit, and create a sustainable pathway for mission-aligned external publishing work that strengthens K-State's reputation and public-service role.

3. Stabilize OER funding and endow the OER librarian role

OER is one of OPE's clearest student-facing impact areas. In 2026, the department should strengthen OER funding through Student Government Association support, continued alignment with BOER, and a long-term development strategy that turns the OER librarian position into an endowed role.

The case is straightforward: OER lowers student costs, supports teaching innovation, and produces measurable public value. Endowing the position would protect a proven affordability program from annual budget volatility while signaling that textbook affordability is a permanent K-State priority.

4. Make OPE evidence-driven

OPE should build a simple annual evidence framework that reports activity, outcomes, and return on institutional investment across all four service lines. The point is not to reduce open work to dashboards alone, but to make visible the labor, value, and impact of OPE services.

- OER: student savings, courses supported, faculty participants, adoptions, remixes, and open textbook outputs.
- Repository: deposits, downloads, metadata quality, public-access compliance support, ETDR/RSCAD throughput, and preservation actions.
- NPP: publications hosted, editorial projects supported, downloads, accessibility remediation, external partners, and cost-recovery activity.
- Data Services: grants supported, DMPs reviewed, repository consultations, datasets published, PIDs created, and research collaborations.

Priority Staffing Needs

The 2026-27 staffing request should be narrow and strategic, if made at all. Rather than presenting a long wish list, OPE should lead with two positions that unlock sustainability across multiple service lines.

Scholarly Communications Editor

A Scholarly Communications Editor would support both NPP and OER by improving editorial workflows, publication quality, accessibility, copyediting coordination, editor training, style guidance, and project completion. This role would allow OPE faculty and librarians to focus more fully on program development, partnerships, research, and higher-level publishing strategy.

Project Coordinator for Grant Work

A Project Coordinator would manage timelines, documentation, MOUs, partner communication, grant deliverables, reporting, invoicing support, and evidence collection for sponsored and external-facing work. The position should be designed as a pooled grant-support role rather than a single-project position. OPE should plan to distribute the coordinator across grants, with a target of no fewer than three active grants carrying appropriate portions of the role. This model would give OPE needed operational capacity while demonstrating a sustainable staffing approach for research-support services.

Longer-Term Capacity Questions

Two related capacity problems should be treated as part of the long-term OPE sustainability agenda rather than as isolated staffing wishes.

First, OPE needs a durable model for pooled software engineering hours. Repository infrastructure, publishing platforms, metadata pipelines, accessibility workflows, API integrations, and research dashboards all require small but recurring technical work. A shared software engineering pool, funded

through a combination of grants, infrastructure budgets, and project MOUs, would be more realistic than expecting each service line to carry its own developer capacity.

Second, OPE should explore how to mentor graduate students within a lab-like structure. Graduate assistants can provide meaningful capacity for data curation, publishing workflows, OER production, repository projects, and scholarly communication research, but only if they are supported through a coherent mentoring model. Over time, OPE should develop a small research-and-practice lab that connects graduate student labor, grant-funded projects, applied learning, and OPE faculty research.

Together, pooled software engineering and graduate-student mentoring would help OPE move from project-by-project improvisation toward a more durable research infrastructure model.

Long-Term Outlook

OPE's long-term focus should be building sustainable, evidence-driven services while developing a parallel research program. This means the department should continue to operate essential platforms and services, but also study and publish from that work: how open textbooks affect student affordability, how institutional repositories support public access, how Diamond OA and library publishing can be funded responsibly, how research data services improve grant competitiveness, and how scholarly outputs are used beyond traditional publication counts.

By 2030, OPE should be recognized as a durable part of K-State's research and teaching infrastructure: a department that lowers costs, increases access, supports compliance, improves publication quality, preserves outputs, helps win grants, and produces scholarship about the future of open knowledge systems.

Near-Term Actions for 2026

1. Finalize OPE identity language and align public-facing descriptions across the Libraries website, NPP, K-REx, OER pages, and grant-support materials.

2. Draft and approve a standard MOU template for external NPP use.

3. Define a grant-support intake workflow for data services and publishing support.

4. Build an OER sustainability case for SGA, BOER, Libraries leadership, and potential donors.

5. Create an annual OPE evidence report with a small set of metrics for each service line.

6. Prioritize hiring or funding pathways for a Scholarly Communications Editor and a grant-distributed Project Coordinator.

7. Develop a pooled software engineering model for recurring technical work across repository, publishing, data services, and reporting projects.

8. Define a graduate-student mentoring model that can support OPE service work and the department's emerging research program.